the gap. One troop of the AMX-13 tanks under the command of Captain A. K. Dewan was also in the vicinity, supplementing with their guns the accurate fire from 13 Field Regiment's 25-pounders which probably deterred the Chinese from pushing forward with their armour.

The exchange of fire continued throughout 18 and 19 November. With both the airfield and the village under constant artillery fire, reinforcements and supply of the forward positions was proving to be a problem. Rezang-la having fallen, 114 Brigade faced the danger of the Chushul-Dungti-Leh axis being cut off. To further complicate matters, Chinese shelling had snapped all communications between Gurung Hill and Brigade HQ. The only way to get to the Gorkha positions was to cross the flat tract of land and run the gauntlet of Chinese fire. As a result, even though the fighting was raging in front of them, Brigade HQ was not fully aware of the situation.

Accordingly, despite the successful defence of Gurung Hill, Raina ordered the withdrawal at 6 p.m. on 19 November. Contact was broken during the night and by first light on 20 November Trench Hill had been abandoned. Six men in this position had been killed and four wounded. The story at Foot Hill, more of a staging camp for the troops manning the ridge, was much the same as that of Trench Hill. By the time this post was abandoned, the platoon had lost nine men, with one wounded.

After the withdrawal of the Gorkhas, the Chinese once again made no move to occupy these two positions.

Bravo Company of 13 Kumaon under the command of Captain Chauhan was holding Paw Hill that guarded the approach to the eastern perimeter of the Chushul airfield. In terms of both men and firepower, the Paw Hill post was by far the most strongly held. In support of the Kumaonis troops, there was also a section of 3-inch mortars, one section of anti-tank guns (two RCLs) and a platoon of MMGs. This post was the first to come under Chinese bombardment on the morning of 18 November and like Trench Hill and Foot Hill, continued to exchange fire with the Chinese. However, despite the shelling and the occasional probe to test their defences, Chinese infantry did not directly attack either Paw Hill or Mugger Hill.

On the afternoon of 19 November Bikram Singh and Raina held a conference at Brigade HQ amidst the shelling. All junior officers were pleading for a chance to counter-attack the Chinese and take back Rezang-la. However, still anticipating a major Chinese attack through the Spanggur